

PAOLA ADVENTURER



Family Camping Planner

Your stress-free starter kit for a first family trip

Not another blank checklist. A real outdoorswoman and mom walks you through the whole trip, so nothing gets forgotten and no one panics. Planning, packing, meals, safety, real tips, and what to do when things go sideways.

Trip Planner

WHERE WE'RE GOING

CAMPGROUND / SITE #

ARRIVE

LEAVE

NIGHTS

WHO'S COMING

RESERVATION CONFIRMED?

BUDGET

WEATHER FORECAST & NOTES

NEAREST TOWN / HOSPITAL

Pre-Trip Countdown

Check it off as you go

2 Weeks Before

- ☐ Book / confirm the campsite
- ☐ Check the weather
- ☐ Plan the meals
- ☐ Test the tent & gear
- ☐ Charge batteries / power banks

Few Days Before

- ☐ Grocery shopping
- ☐ Refill first-aid kit
- ☐ Do the packing lists
- ☐ Freeze water bottles / ice
- ☐ Fill the car with gas

Day Before

- ☐ Pack the cooler
- ☐ Load the car
- ☐ Print this planner & the kids' pack
- ☐ Share the plan with a friend

Leaving Day

- ☐ Water & snacks in reach
- ☐ Phones charged
- ☐ Trash bags & wipes
- ☐ Lock up the house

Master Packing List

Check each one you pack

Shelter & Sleep

- ☐ Tent + stakes
- ☐ Sleeping bags
- ☐ Pillows & blankets
- ☐ Sleeping pads / air mattress
- ☐ Tarp / ground cover

Camp Kitchen

- ☐ Cooler + ice
- ☐ Stove / fuel
- ☐ Pot, pan, spatula
- ☐ Plates, cups, utensils
- ☐ Matches / lighter
- ☐ Dish soap & sponge

Clothing

- ☐ Layers & jackets
- ☐ Rain gear
- ☐ Extra socks & shoes
- ☐ Hats & gloves
- ☐ Swimsuits & towels

Tools & Extras

- ☐ Flashlights / lantern
- ☐ Power bank
- ☐ Camp chairs
- ☐ Multi-tool / knife
- ☐ Rope / paracord
- ☐ Bug spray & sunscreen

Kids & Toiletries List

Kids

- ☐ Comfort item / stuffed animal
- ☐ Extra clothes (they get muddy!)
- ☐ Kids' Outdoor Adventure Pack
- ☐ Water bottles
- ☐ Kid-safe flashlight
- ☐ Sun hat
- ☐ Snacks they love

Toiletries

- ☐ Toothbrushes & paste
- ☐ Biodegradable soap
- ☐ Toilet paper
- ☐ Wet wipes
- ☐ Hand sanitizer
- ☐ Towels
- ☐ Medications

Mom tip: pack one full outfit per kid per day, plus two extras. Kids + dirt = a guarantee.

Meal Planner

DAY	BREAKFAST	LUNCH	DINNER	SNACKS
Day 1				
Day 2				
Day 3				
Day 4				

Easy camp dinners: foil-packet fajitas · hot dogs & beans · pasta & jarred sauce · walking tacos · grilled cheese. And of course... s'mores. 🍫

Camp Grocery List

By section, so nothing's forgotten

Proteins

- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐

Produce

- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐

Pantry & Snacks

- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐

Drinks & Extras

- ☐
- ☐
- ☐
- ☐

First-Aid & Safety

First-Aid Kit

- ☐ Band-aids & gauze
- ☐ Antiseptic wipes
- ☐ Tweezers (ticks & splinters)
- ☐ Pain / fever medicine
- ☐ Allergy medicine
- ☐ Aloe / burn gel
- ☐ Any personal meds

Safety Check

- ☐ Store food away from tent
- ☐ Know the bear rules
- ☐ Fire fully out before bed
- ☐ Kids know the meeting spot
- ☐ Flashlight for each person
- ☐ Emergency contacts saved

Free bonus: grab our Bear Country Cheat Sheet at paolaadventurer.com before you go.

Family Emergency Card

Fill it in, keep it in the car

NAME	AGE	ALLERGIES	MEDICATIONS

EMERGENCY CONTACT

THEIR PHONE

.....

.....

FAMILY DOCTOR

INSURANCE INFO

NEAREST HOSPITAL

PARK RANGER / OFFICE

.....

.....

OUR CAMPSITE ADDRESS / GPS

.....

Camp Chore Chart

Everyone helps, camp runs smooth

JOB	WHO'S ON IT	DONE
Gather firewood		
Set up / take down tent		
Cook the meal		
Wash the dishes		
Take out the trash		
Refill water		
Tidy the tent		

Mom win: let the kids pick their jobs, they help way more when they choose.

BONUS

5 Easy Campfire Meals

Kid-approved

Foil-Packet Fajitas

Sliced chicken or beef + peppers + onion + taco seasoning. Wrap in foil, cook on coals 15-20 min. Serve in tortillas.

Walking Tacos

Crush a bag of chips, add warm seasoned beef, cheese, lettuce & salsa right in the bag. No dishes!

Campfire Nachos

Chips + beans + cheese in a foil tray. Cover & heat by the fire until melty. Top with whatever you've got.

Banana Boats

Slit a banana (in peel), stuff with chocolate & mini marshmallows, wrap in foil, warm 5 min. Dessert!

Breakfast Burritos

Scramble eggs + cheese + pre-cooked sausage, roll in a tortilla. Make ahead & reheat in foil.

Classic S'mores

Graham cracker + chocolate + toasted marshmallow. The one everyone remembers. 

Prep tip: chop and season everything at home in labeled bags, camp cooking becomes 10 minutes.

What Nobody Tells You

The stuff I learned the hard way, so you don't have to

Arrive with daylight

Get there 2+ hours before dark. Setting up a tent in the dark with tired kids is a special kind of chaos.

One bin per category

Kitchen in one bin, sleep in another, first-aid in another. No digging through bags at night.

Freeze your water bottles

They keep the cooler cold AND become drinking water as they melt. Two jobs, one bottle.

Baby wipes are the MVP

Hands, faces, spills, quick "showers," even dishes. Bring double what you think.

A doormat saves your tent

A cheap mat at the tent door cuts the dirt inside in half. Shoes off, always.

Pack extra socks

Wet socks ruin moods faster than anything. Bring way more than seems reasonable.

Give each kid a flashlight

It becomes their prized possession, and it keeps them close after dark.

Familiar pillow = better sleep

A pillow and small night-light from home help little ones sleep in a new place.

Set Up Camp in Order

Do it in this order and setup is calm, not chaos

1

Pick your spot. Flat ground, not under dead branches, slightly high (water runs downhill if it rains).

2

Lay the ground cover / tarp first. It protects the tent floor and keeps it dry.

3

Pitch the tent while you have daylight and helpers. This is the big one, do it first.

4

Make the beds now. Sleeping bags, pads, and pillows in before it gets dark.

5

Set up the kitchen zone. Away from the tent, on a flat surface.

6

Store all food in the car or cooler. Never in the tent (bears and ants).

7

Gather firewood before sunset. Hunting for wood in the dark is no fun.

8

Set out chairs and the lantern. Now sit down, you earned it.

When Things Go Sideways

Because something always does, here's what to do

It starts raining

Move activities under a tarp or into the car.
Play cards, do the kids' pack, tell stories.
Dry clothes ready for bedtime.

Too many bugs

Bug spray at dusk, long sleeves, and keep food sealed. A citronella candle helps at the table.

A kid won't sleep

Familiar pillow, night-light, and a calm routine. A little white noise (a fan app) covers scary night sounds.

You forgot something

Breathe. Most things you can improvise or buy at the camp store / nearest town. It's rarely a trip-ender.

Someone's cold at night

Hat on, dry socks, and a layer between them and the ground. Cold comes from below, not just the air.

A kid is scared

Name it, normalize it, give them a "job" (hold the flashlight). Confidence beats fear every time.

Your Weekend, Done For You

A ready-to-go 2-night plan, copy it or make it yours

DAY	BREAKFAST	LUNCH	DINNER	SNACKS
Day 1	Eat before you leave	Sandwiches on arrival	Foil-packet fajitas	Trail mix, s'mores
Day 2	Breakfast burritos	Walking tacos	Hot dogs & beans	Fruit, s'mores
Day 3	Oatmeal / cereal	Leftovers / road snacks	(home!)	Crackers

1 **Day 1:** Arrive by 3pm, set up camp, easy dinner, first campfire and s'mores.

2 **Day 2:** Breakfast, morning nature walk (bring the Kids' Adventure Pack!), lunch, free play or water in the afternoon, dinner, then stargazing.

3 **Day 3:** Slow breakfast, pack up, do a "leave no trace" sweep, drive home with happy, tired kids.

3 Skills to Teach Your Kids

Little wins that build big outdoor confidence

1. Build & put out a campfire (with an adult)

Teach the three sizes: tiny **tinder** (dry grass), thin **kindling** (twigs), then **logs**. To put it out: **drown** it with water, **stir** the ashes, **feel** for heat. Never leave a fire alone.

2. Stay found: the "Hug a Tree" rule

If they ever feel lost: **stop, stay put, and hug a tree**. Don't wander. Blow a whistle three times and wait. It's always easier for a grown-up to find a child who stays in one place.

3. Leave No Trace

Pack out every piece of trash, leave rocks, plants, and bugs where they are, and leave the campsite better than you found it. Teach them: **"take only pictures, leave only footprints."**

Why it matters: kids who learn one real skill come home proud, and way more excited for the next trip.

Trip Memories

BEST MOMENT

FUNNIEST THING THAT HAPPENED

WHAT WE'D DO DIFFERENTLY NEXT TIME

RATE THE TRIP

☆ ☆ ☆ ☆ ☆

WHERE TO NEXT?
